

Privacy in the Digital Age

Identify Specific Scenarios:

- **Describe a situation involving privacy and data security:** A situation where I feel directly involved in and am both making decisions with and facing challenges related to privacy and data security is the exchange of personal information for convenience. More specifically, I feel that the convenience of our daily lives requires us to be willing to reveal our data to take advantage of technology's assistance. Whether it be our music-listening history, diets, physical activity, 24/7 conversations, or interests, we are giving away information so that we may receive assistance on a day to day basis. We may choose to opt-out of certain usages, but I feel that we are becoming more dependent on technology.
- **Reflect on the emotions, thoughts, and motivations involved:** As time goes on, I have more concerns about how our information is used and can be shared. There are some tools that I have decided to opt-out of such as summoning Google at any given moment by speaking to it. I had grown hesitant to the idea of constantly being listened to and have taken this logic and applied it to other applications of my life. Although, I feel that there are some unavoidable data usages in things like navigation systems, social media, streaming platforms, and apps in general.
- **Consider the perspectives of all involved parties:** I feel that in the specific instance of opting-out of Google's Assistant summoning, I allowed my own and other's (in my vicinity) conversations to not be monitored through my cellphone. On a greater scale, although I am not necessarily promoting Google by not participating in one of its features, I believe that I am standing with those who do not wish to be listened to at all times by large companies for reasons which could benefit their business.

Connect to Privacy Principles:

- **Relate your experience to key privacy principles:** When it comes to the instance of audible assistance in this specific situation, there are many fundamental privacy principles to consider like data protection, user consent, transparency, and information security. I feel that there is a struggle with securing my privacy and technological efficiency. I like to prioritize user consent, but balancing privacy with convenience when convenience depends on using our data. When our actions are being monitored in the name of assistance, our data is not necessarily protected when it is given away to companies outside of ones we use like Google. We may give or revoke consent, but sometimes these apps are able to bypass our say. Although most of the time, our terms and conditions of applications we are using are stated (typically in a complex, cryptic manner), the regular user will not periodically check up on this crucial information which usually changes without an announcement. When using Google, we are told that our information is secure, but sometimes we do not know the extent to which our information is being leaked, mined, taken, and so on. These various principles are at risk on the regular, and in some instances, there may not be much we can do but try our best to cut these tools off completely.
- **Reflect on how these principles guided your actions:** Data protection, user consent, transparency, and information security have influenced my decisions during this scenario by reminding me that there are some boundaries that should be practiced when utilizing technology. I have faced dilemmas of debating whether I would like to keep my information private, or if there are some applications and tools that I may not be able to part with. When it comes to my music streaming services, social media, and searching engines, I am not able to say goodbye to them at this time, since they are a regular part of my life. Although I have not stopped using these apps, I try my best to limit what I am sharing that may be personal and I customize my

privacy settings. I know that I should not be partaking in companies that do not align with my privacy values and morals, but in an age where technological usage and wireless communication is beyond common, it has been challenging to not participate in the normalities. A quote that stuck out to me in an article from Pew Research Center is that “Public norms will continue to trend toward the desire for more privacy, while people’s actions will tend toward giving up more and more control over their data” (Rainie & Anderson, 2014). If I could go back in time before I started using some platforms like social media(s) or search engines like Google, I would consider not signing up, so that I would not be as concerned about my privacy as I am now.

Analyze Impact:

- **Reflect on how this experience deepened your understanding of privacy:** This scenario influenced my understanding of privacy and data security by allowing me to research the privacy principles as well as challenge my assumptions and knowledge about how technology and companies are using our information. I feel that my existing, although stronger now, beliefs have been more solidified on what I believe about privacy in this digital age. I believe that my personal values and ethical perspectives are challenged when I partake in the usage of technology usages that I objectively should abstain from. Although, I have become more educated and knowledgeable on how crucial our digital privacy is from our class lectures and my own research.
- **Analyze the long-term impact of your decisions:** Thinking of the broader and long-term implications of the choices I made with the decision to not use Google Assistant, I feel that I have greatened my mission to protect my personal information from companies that do not need it. I have shared my findings with others in hopes that they too will opt out of conveniences that mine their data. In a publication by PubMed Central, three authors speak on

mobile health applications which take part in “trading privacy for the convenience of achieving a user's goals” (Ozeran et al., 2021). The passage explains the risks and concerns that come with using health apps where personal information is shared, which shows that there is the pressing issue of privacy of users, even in the medical field. This experience has altered my view of privacy in both my personal and professional life by casting a light on the importance of reserving myself online as much as I can from those who I do not want to know private things about myself. I did not know the full extent that posts, comments, websites, media, and more can be spread without my knowledge until I had done my own research and taken the time to learn about this pressing issue.

Personal Insights:

- **Share profound insights about the importance of privacy:** Some insights and realizations that I have gained on the critical role of privacy in today's society goes as follows: With the increase of automation and convenience, there is an equal and consequential decrease in privacy. With the terms of benefitting a user, the user loses private information on given sites, apps, and more. That release of data can be sent or given to anyone, anything, or anywhere once out in the world. We are given automation and assistance at the cost of data and privacy, in a world where technology is becoming more popular and depended on. There is also a draw since old methods of life are becoming obsolete & we are preferring the ease of tasks. In the past, we did not have as much convenience as now, but interestingly, life was also much simpler.
- **Discuss how this experience has shifted your ethical perspective:** Reflect on any shifts in your ethical perspective regarding privacy. How has this experience changed your approach to handling privacy issues in the future? Discuss how you plan to uphold privacy principles in your future work,

studies, or personal life, emphasizing any new strategies or considerations you intend to adopt.

- I feel that my ethical perspectives on privacy have been shifted, but have been shifted in the way where my knowledge on the matter has deepened. This experience has changed my approach to handling privacy issues in the future by giving me a greater methodical approach to making sure I take the appropriate precautions in instances where my personal information may be released. I wish to uphold these principles in my work, studies, and personal life by making sure to deeply understand privacy statements, adjust privacy settings, make sure I agree to application's terms, and regularly check for updates on sites, apps, and media that I use. Forming these good habits to ensure my personal privacy's security, I will be more safe from the unwanted spread of my information where avoidable.

Works Cited

Rainie, L., & Anderson, J. (2014, December 18). *The Future of Privacy*. Pew Research Center.

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Ozeran, L., Solomonides, A., & Schreiber, R. (2021, May 5). *Privacy versus convenience: A historical perspective, analysis of risks, and an informatics call to action*. Applied clinical informatics.

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